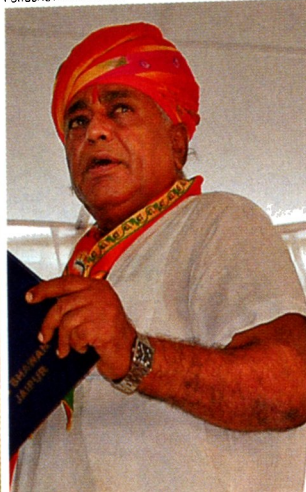


PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



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Foes and Friends

AIPUR Enemies and allies change their colours in politics like chameleons. This time round, it is Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje who is showing great generosity to two of her former adversaries in an attempt to carry both Jats and Rajputs along with her government.

Her latest political muse is Devi Singh Bhatti, a Rajput leader from Bikaner who had earlier opposed Raje's appointment as state BJP president. Raje has now inducted Bhatti into the Cabinet as minister for

tourism and excise, previously her own portfolios. It is clear that she is keen to undo the damage done to the BJP in Bikaner by its mostly-absentee MP, the actor Dharmendra.

Bhatti is known for his aggression. In 1997, he was sacked by chief minister Bhairon Singh Shekhawat from his cabinet after an assault on P.K. Deb, an IAS officer, by Bhatti and his cohorts. Undaunted, Bhatti and Co went on to disrupt Raje's Parivartan Yatra and even attacked BJP leader Gulab Chand Kataria's caravan.

NEW MUSE: Raje, Bhatti

He then took on BJP stalwart Atal Bihari Vajpayee, disrupting his rally in Jaipur. However, Bhatti's change of heart apparently came when he lost his son Mahendra Singh, a former MP, in a road accident. Five years earlier, he had lost his wife and younger son in a similar mishap.

Raje has also bestowed a cabinet rank on Vishwendra Singh, MP and erstwhile maharaja of Bharatpur. Until recently, Singh is known to have been a strong Raje detractor. He had voiced his vehement differences to her over the Gurjar issue even while acting as a mediator between the two parties. During the agitation, Vishwendra had demanded authorisation as the government's official representative, which was shot down by Raje.

In old Rajasthan, a red-blooded feud could keep simmering for generations. Today, though making up with old foes for one's own political interests is clearly the order of the day. **by Rohit Parihar**

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: CPI(M) leader **P. Ramachandran**, 83. He was a Politburo member for 13 years since 1992.

CONFERRED: On filmmaker **Yash Chopra**, the Officier de la Legion d'Honneur, the



highest French distinction, for his contribution to Indian cinema.

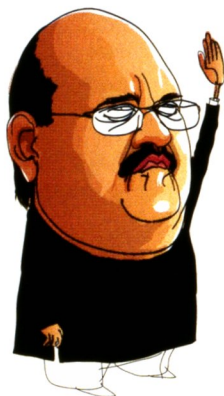
The award was instituted by Napoleon Bonaparte in 1802.

NAMED: Cricketer **Sourav Ganguly** as the Castrol Asian Cricketer of the Year by the Asian Cricket Council in Karachi with **Sachin Tendulkar** being named the ACC's best Asian one-day batsman.

QUIT: Maharashtra minister of state for social justice, transport and tribal welfare, **Dharmarao Baba Atram**. He is accused of killing an endangered chinkara on the night of June 14 near Baramati.

VIS-A-VIS **AMAR SINGH** Samajwadi Party general secretary **versus** **M. VENKAIAH NAIDU** BJP leader

For us, communalism is a bigger danger than imperialism. Advani is a bigger danger than George Bush.



SAURABH SINGH

It has become a tradition and fashion for political leaders to talk about secularism whenever they are in trouble or change loyalties.

EPILOGUE: Changing loyalties is not the new name of the game in Indian politics.